

Chinese bamboo rat

Rhizomys sinensis

- ↔ 9–16 in (22–40 cm)
- 📍 E. Asia
- ⊗ Common

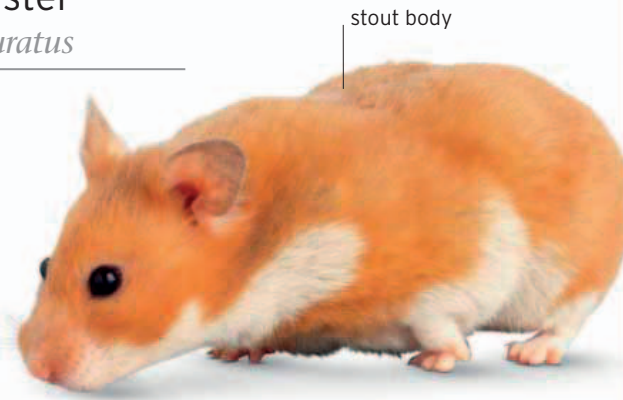
The stocky, soft-furred bamboo rat is well-named, for it lives in bamboo thickets and feeds almost entirely on bamboo shoots and roots. It digs extensive burrow systems up to 150 ft (45 m) long, breeding in a nest chamber lined with bamboo leaves. Widespread across southern China and Southeast Asia, this rat can be common enough to be regarded as a plantation pest in some areas.

Golden hamster

Mesocricetus auratus

- ↔ 5 in (13 cm)
- 📍 W. Asia
- ⊗ Vulnerable

Native to the borderlands between Syria and Turkey, this golden-furred rodent is far more familiar as a pet. It has a broad diet including seeds, nuts, and insects, and lives in a burrow that can be as deep as 7 ft (2 m). In the wild, it feeds mainly at



night, but carries food back to the nest in its large cheek pouches to eat during the day.

White-footed mouse

Peromyscus leucopus

- ↔ 3–4 in (7.6–10.1 cm)
- 📍 SE. Canada to Mexico
- ⊗ Common

Common and widespread throughout central and eastern North America, aside from the far north, this small mouse usually lives in pairs in a sheltered den beneath tree roots or stones, or in a burrow. The mice stay hidden by day and forage at night for seeds, berries, and insects. They often take food back to the den, covering it with soil to hide it.

Giant South American water rat

Kunsia tomentosus

- ↔ 12 in (30 cm)
- 📍 C. South America
- ⊗ Locally common

This large rat is found in wet grasslands in Brazil and Bolivia. Despite its name, the giant water rat is a burrower rather than a swimmer, spending most of its time below ground, where it tunnels beneath plants and eats their roots. During the tropical rainy season, the rat's tunnels are often inundated by floodwater, forcing it to feed on grasses and green shoots of other plants on the surface.

Muskrat

Ondatra zibethicus

- ↔ 10–14 in (25–35 cm)
- 📍 North America, W. Europe to N. and E. Asia
- ⊗ Common

The largest of the voles, the beaver-like muskrat is specialized for swimming with webbed hindfeet and a flattened tail that it can use as a rudder. It lives in family groups, in riverbank burrows or in mounds of twigs, reeds, and mud. Mainly active by night, it eats water plants such as reeds and water lilies, plus a few small aquatic animals. Native to North America, it has been introduced to Eurasia, where it is now widespread.

Eurasian water vole

Arvicola amphibius

- ↔ 5–9 in (12–23 cm)
- 📍 W. Europe to W. and N. Asia
- ⊗ Common

As its name indicates, the water vole is adapted for life in slow-moving rivers, streams, and wetlands and is an adept swimmer and diver. It feeds on a variety of waterside plants, consuming up to 80 percent of its body weight every day. Water voles that mainly burrow in meadows and woods are almost half the size of those that live in river banks. Both types have thick fur, which is gray, brown, or black on the upperparts and dark gray to white below.



Common vole

Microtus arvalis

- ↔ 4–5 in (10–13 cm)
- 📍 W. Europe to W. and C. Asia
- ⊗ Common

The small, stocky, blunt-snouted common vole is very common on Eurasian grasslands, farmland, and other open habitats. Its main food is grass, but it also eats a variety of leafy farm crops, as

well as soft bark in winter. The common vole makes tunnel-like runways through the grass for easy access to feeding areas and maintains them even under snow cover in winter. It also digs shallow burrows for sleeping, breeding, and storing food.



Brown lemming

Lemmus sibiricus

- ↔ 5–6 in (12–15 cm)
- 📍 N. Asia
- ⊗ Common

The short, rounded body of this volelike rodent is the ideal shape for conserving body heat in the Arctic tundra. In winter, it forages beneath the snow, which insulates it from the bitterly cold wind and hides it from predators such as snowy owls. It feeds on plants, breeding prolifically when food is plentiful. The brown lemming migrates to higher ground in summer, but does not make mass migrations, unlike some other lemming species.

Fat-tailed jird

Pachyuromys duprasi

- ↔ 4–5 in (10–13 cm)
- 📍 N. Africa
- ⊗ Common

Adapted for life in the North African desert, this small, soft-furred rodent has a pointed snout and long rear feet. It is named for its stout, hairless tail, which stores energy-rich body fat like the hump of a camel. The jird spends most of the day in a burrow, insulated from the burning sun, and emerges at dusk to hunt through the night for insects and spiders. It also eats some plant matter such as leaves and seeds.